THE TELESERIALS

WHEN SMALL TURNS BIG

In the Eighties, Indian television went from a dull grey box to the full colours of immersive storytelling. The multichannel revolution was waiting to explode on the other side

BY SUHANI SINGH



SERIAL SEDUCTION The *Hum Log* cast



Divine Sensation

At first glance everything seems to be wrong with *Ramayan*, Ramanand Sagar's

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Television
Ramayan: Divine Sensation

TV serial that started late January... *Ramayan* has all the finesse of a high school function. And yet seldom has a television serial aroused such a phenomenal response.
–Simran Bhargava

In the India of 1975, the small screen was... *pretty* small. It had only been a decade since daily telecasts began, four hours of sputtering B&W visuals—in two capsules, morning and evening. 'Sorry for the Interruption' may have been the longest-running programme. There was only Doordarshan, and Doordarshan didn't go very far. Only seven cities, its stations still a stepney to AIR. The maximum possible audience was five million. That graph wasn't exactly stagnant—thanks to *Chitrahaar*, cricket and class mobility—but the real liftoff was awaited. That came with Asiad '82, when there was a flood of light—and colour. Literally. India's first major international sporting competition was preceded by the launch of INSAT-1a (an early demise hastened 1b) and the introduction of colour television. But the technological fits and restarts were only one part, the juice was in the content.

It's with *Hum Log*, beginning 1984, that Indians discovered TV could be seriously habit-forming. Though aligned